Foreword
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Foreword

The Archive, Scholarship, and Kant

In his description of a certain Chinese encyclopedia, Jorge Luis Borges classified animals as "(a) belonging to the Emperor, (b) embalmed, (c) tame, (d) suckling pigs, (e) sirens, (f) fabulous, (g) stray dogs, (h) included in the present classification." Classifications are a search of order, or for illusions of order. Their purpose, we can assume, is to mobilize knowledge for use. What kind of order does Borges suggest? A parody of classification, a taxonomic nightmare. But the stray dogs might interest us. Facts are like stray dogs, wandering into various categories. Borges's encyclopedic archive is itself a stray dog, one that, following any meditation on Borges, opens infinite pastures of time and memory.

In terms of time and memory, the Getty Research Institute's extraordinary archives are Borgesian in their imaginative reach. Infinite facts ride on seas of data, corralled into spacious rooms (periods), all carefully classified by the Shem and Shaun of taxonomy, author and subject. And beyond that, into infinite Linnaean branches. Since the passing of formalism, the visual arts' Esperanto, the archive has assumed a glamour, a radiance that its keepers and users share. Cultural memory, that which is preserved through accident and intention, is as insecure as what individual memory preserves. Archivists are, by profession, ideology-free. For them, the past is their limitless field for hunting and gathering. Memory is assembled document by document, fact by fact. How the past is mobilized and conveyed to the future through journals like this is another open field where fictions of objectivity meet varieties of ideology, all presented as truth that must, through the nature of scholarship, prevail through expected opposition.

Thus the exhilaration of those of us who use, as visitors or fellows, the archive. Artworks, as we receive them, are progressively deprived of context, and what is the archive but an encyclopedia of lost contexts waiting to be reconstituted? No wonder at times that, revisualized in the rich matrices of the archive, the single artwork on the museum wall seems transparent, less secure, open to varieties of interpretation. It is to the interpreters, the scholars, that this journal has dedicated itself. And to the issues that circulate between the trinity of artwork, museum, and audience.

New subjects often invent themselves when an emphasis is placed where there was none. In recent years, the presentation of the artwork and its reception have provided us with another twined subject. The once neutral space between the artwork and

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the observer's eye is now crowded with speculation and theory. Art history calls on other disciplines, particularly anthropology, to study the patient figure before the artwork, who is waiting for enlightenment. Even neurology, currently mapping areas of the brain that respond to aesthetic stimuli, begins to make a tentative claim for consideration.

At the center of these speculations is the art historian, whose profession was sympathetically described by George Steiner in "The Cleric of Treason" (1980), who was writing about the fate of Anthony Blunt, Poussin's lover and the Queen's traitor. Steiner describes the harsh disciplines in which the art historian—and it may be said, the often-despised connoisseur—must be versed.

> Memory, the retention before the mind's eye of a great range of surrounding, ancillary, comparable or contrasting art, is indispensable. So is historical imagination, the stab of precise sympathy that enables a historical novelist, a historian, a great stage designer to image the past. Sheer erudition—that is a voluminous intimacy with the artist's biography, with his professional habits, with the material distribution and survival of the works as they left his atelier and begin their often tortuous journey towards the modern museum, auction room, neglected attic, or private collection—is essential . . . [as is] the ability to bring taste and sensory awareness to bear unswervingly on the art object both in its minutest details and in its overall effect. The master cataloguer has perfect pitch.

Astonishingly, Steiner goes on to posit the archivist's and art historian's anger. The "discipline of investing one's waking dreams in the always vulnerable elucidation of abstruse problems accessible only to a handful of prying and rival colleagues can secrete a rare venom of the spirit." Overstated, perhaps, and far from confined to art history. Every discipline establishes its margins and limits, as it does with each category within that discipline. Competitive interpretations abound. Transgression is dangerous, originality often punished. I prefer to think of the redemptive graces of great art historians I have met. And they prompt me to return to the old Immanuel Kant struggling to leave his bed to greet a visitor, who suggested he continue to rest. But Kant persisted, saying, "I have not yet lost my humanitas." Or so I remember it. The archive will confirm.

Brian O'Doherty, *formerly Patrick Ireland, is an artist and writer. His work* Tatlin Squared *was done while he was an artist-in-residence at the Getty Research Institute.*

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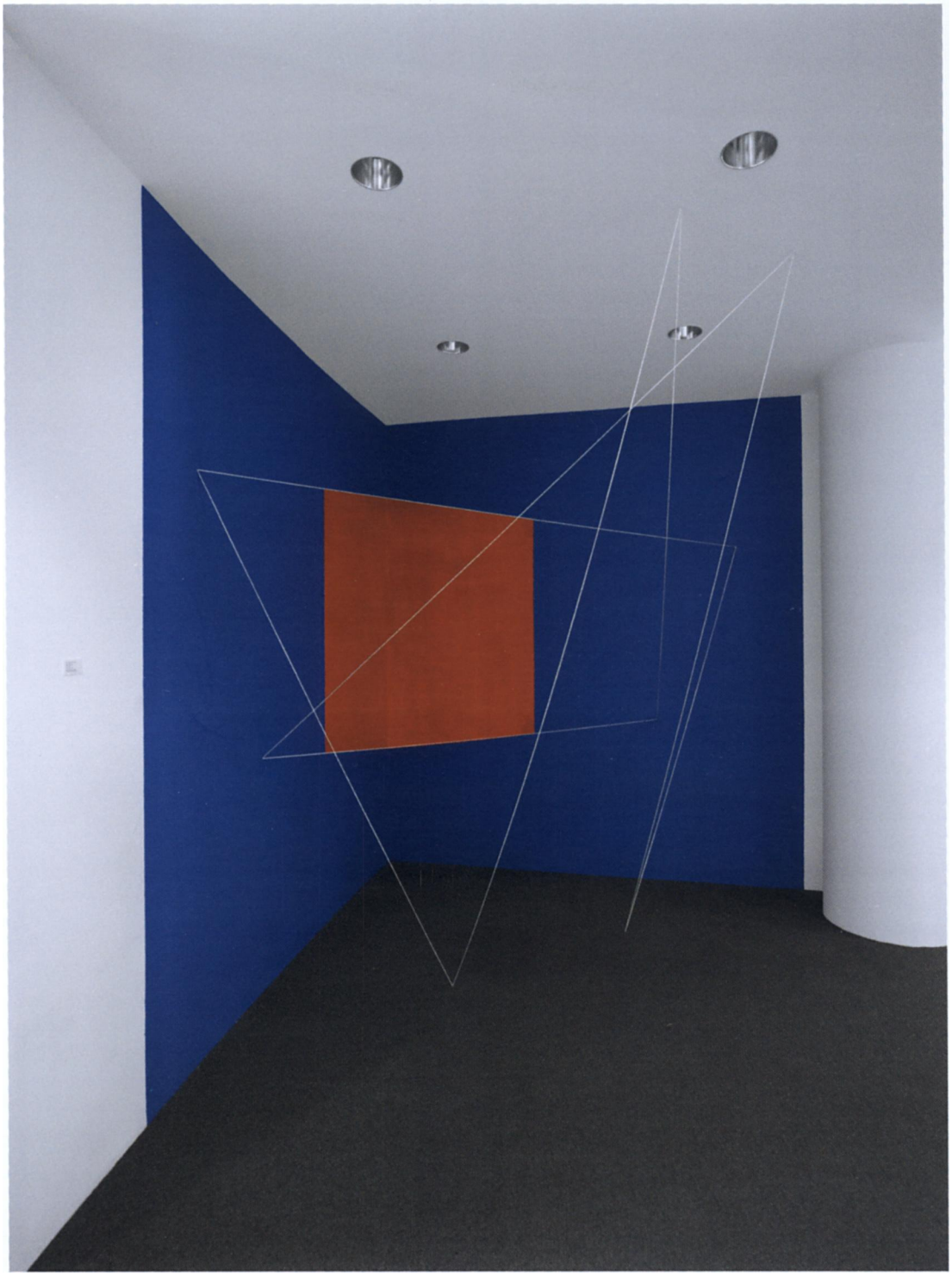

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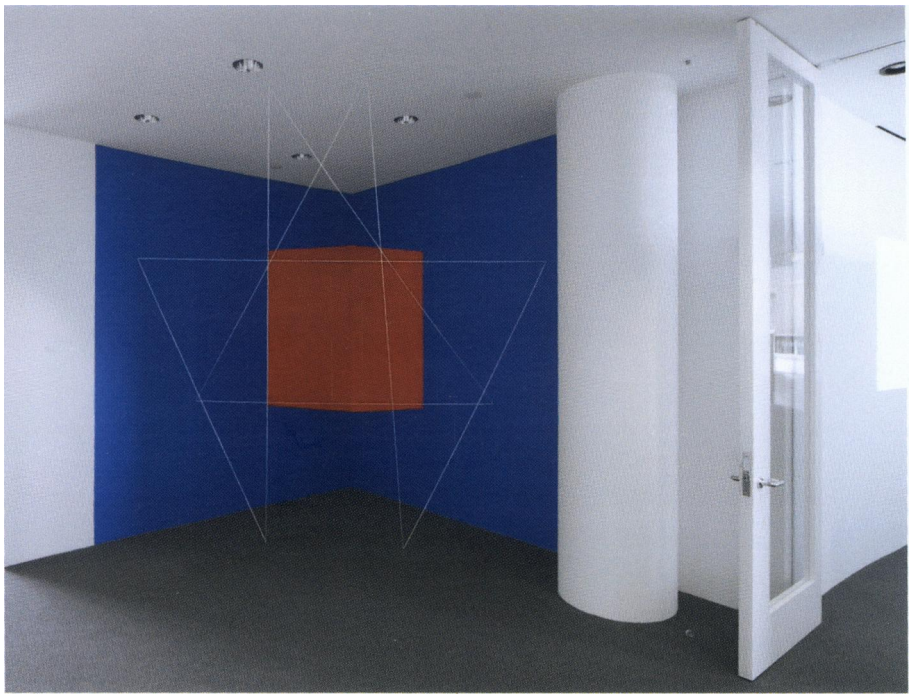

Tatlin Squared

When converging walls meet, the semienclosed wedge of space is turbulent. Why shouldn't it be? There are velocities involved. Add the definers of every indoor corner—the V above, the central seam, the inverted V below—which, if you think about it, offer a faint Vitruvian echo. The empty corner is full of content resisting anything that interferes with its self-definition.

To use the corner's assets against itself, you need to enter a perceptual conspiracy. The (indirect) light must be equalized on each wall, the seam absorbed into whiteness. These diminish the corner's powers.

To cancel the corner, or at least make it a cooperative partner, paint a square of pure color across the seam. Frame it with a string rebounding between walls, ceiling, floor. The red square on a blue ground, now framed in a nest of symmetrical triangles, retreats, advances, becomes solid and atmospheric, surface and depth. The spectator choreographs him- or herself to frame the perfect one-eyed view.

But this is only part of the "entertainment." The slightest move reforms the square (which is really a subtle hexagon). Lateral moves reveal superimpositions, parallaxes, a discourse on make-and-break gestalts. The perceptual motor of this conceit is the corner's efforts to retrieve itself and destroy the contemplative square.

Of course, this is just the artist's talk. The content of the work is probably elsewhere, since everything is completed by the receiver. The square has, as we know, a wonderful modernist pedigree. The corner, usually neglected, a more humble one. Vladimir Evgrafovich Tatlin opened up the corner in 1914–15 with the first corner-piece—which explains the title of this work.

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